Possessive Gerunds

Indulge us to introduce the concept of 'Possessive Gerunds.' This sounds complicated, but it's nothing to worry about!

In short, a possessive gerund is a case where a noun or pronoun modifies the gerund. For example:

*I object to **John's** coming late.*

John = noun

Coming late - gerund phrase

Here "John's coming late" is the object of the preposition "to," and "John's" is a possessive modifier of the gerund "coming."

We use the possessive form before a gerund when the meaning is clearly possessive. For example:

- I appreciate your helping me.
- Please excuse my being late.
- I need to talk to you about your spelling

Why do we use the possessive gerund?

This is the key point - if we don't use a possessive, it changes the meaning. The possessive means that the focus is on the activity, not the person.

If I say: "*I object to **John** coming late*", am I objecting to John or to the activity - coming late? Or if I say "*I appreciate **you** coming here*", am I appreciating you or the fact of your coming here?

If no possessives are used, it is referring to the person (the noun or pronoun) rather than the activity (the gerund).

So we need to use the possessive to ensure it's the *activity* that the verb is referring to:

- *I object to **John's** coming late.*
- *I appreciate **your** helping me.*

In reality we often don't use the possessive gerund but to be grammatically correct, we should be!

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Possessive pronouns before -ing forms

Often in English, we use possessive pronouns to clarify who is performing the action described by an -ing form (also called a gerund). This structure helps make sentences clear and grammatically correct, especially in formal writing and speech. Instead of using an object pronoun (like "me" or "him") before a gerund, the possessive form (such as "my" or "his") is usually preferred.

Why use possessive forms with gerunds?

Using a possessive pronoun before a gerund emphasizes that the action belongs to or is done by a specific person. This distinction can affect both the meaning and the fluency of your sentence. For example, "I appreciate your coming early" is more precise than "I appreciate you coming early," especially in formal contexts.

Common Possessive Pronouns Paired with Gerunds

Possessive forms are often used before gerunds to clearly indicate who performs the action.

- my arriving late → My arriving late caused some confusion.
- your asking questions → Your asking questions helped clarify the issue.
- his forgetting the appointment → His forgetting the appointment delayed the meeting.
- her singing loudly → Her singing loudly disturbed the neighbors.
- its working properly → Its working properly depends on regular maintenance.
- our meeting running long → Our meeting running long affected the schedule.
- their leaving early → Their leaving early surprised the organizers.
- John’s winning the prize → John’s winning the prize made everyone proud.
- Mary’s traveling abroad → Mary’s traveling abroad required careful planning.
- the cat’s sleeping on the bed → The cat’s sleeping on the bed annoyed the owner.
- the company’s expanding operations → The company’s expanding operations created new jobs.

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Comparing possessive vs. object pronouns before -ing forms

It's helpful to see the difference between using a possessive and an object pronoun before a gerund. The possessive is generally more formal and focuses on the action, while using an object pronoun often shifts the focus to the person. Here's a comparison:

Possessive Pronoun + Gerund	Object Pronoun + Gerund
I appreciate **your coming** early.	I appreciate **you coming** early.
She didn't like **his interrupting** her.	She didn't like **him interrupting** her.
We were surprised by **their winning** the award.	We were surprised by **them winning** the award.
They objected to **our leaving** so soon.	They objected to **us leaving** so soon.

When to use this structure

You'll most often see possessive pronouns before gerunds in academic or professional writing, formal emails, and careful speech. In casual conversation, object pronouns with gerunds are increasingly common and generally accepted, but understanding the traditional pattern is helpful for clear and precise communication.

- ✅ Preferred in formal writing: "We appreciate **your joining** us."
- ❌ Less formal/colloquial: "We appreciate **you joining** us."

Mastering this small detail can help you sound more natural and polished in English, especially when clarity and correctness matter.

Formal rule vs spoken English usage

Traditionally, English grammar guides recommend using the possessive form before a gerund. This means that when a noun or pronoun comes before a gerund (a verb ending in *-ing* used as a noun), it should take the possessive case. For example, "I appreciate **your** coming early" is considered more correct in formal writing than "I appreciate **you** coming early."

However, in everyday conversation, native speakers often use the object or subject pronoun instead of the possessive, especially in informal settings. This relaxed approach is widely accepted in speech and even in less formal writing, though it is still frowned upon in academic or professional contexts. The difference is subtle, but it can affect the tone and perceived correctness of your English.

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Typical patterns: formal vs informal

- **Formal/written:** I object to **his** leaving early.
- **Informal/spoken:** I object to **him** leaving early.
- **Formal/written:** We were surprised by **their** winning the award.
- **Informal/spoken:** We were surprised by **them** winning the award.
- **Formal/written:** She didn't mind **my** interrupting.
- **Informal/spoken:** She didn't mind **me** interrupting.
- **Formal/written:** Do you approve of **our** joining the team?
- **Informal/spoken:** Do you approve of **us** joining the team?
- **Formal/written:** There's no chance of **your** passing the test without studying.
- **Informal/spoken:** There's no chance of **you** passing the test without studying.

Comparison of possessive vs object pronoun before gerunds

Possessive Pronoun + Gerund ✅ Formal/Standard	Object Pronoun + Gerund ❌ Informal/Conversational
your coming	you coming
his leaving	him leaving
their winning	them winning
our joining	us joining
my interrupting	me interrupting
her singing	her singing (identical)
its working	it working

Notice that for "her," both the possessive and object forms are "her," so the distinction is only clear from context. In summary, while formal English expects the possessive form before gerunds, everyday usage often relaxes this rule. Being aware of the difference lets you adjust your language to fit the situation—more formal for essays and reports, more relaxed for conversation.

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My doing vs me doing: meaning difference

Understanding the difference between using a possessive pronoun (like *my*) before a gerund versus using an object pronoun (like *me*) is key for clarity and formality in English. Both constructions can appear before a gerund (the *-ing* form of a verb used as a noun), but they often carry slightly different implications and follow different conventions.

Possessive pronoun before a gerund

When a possessive pronoun modifies a gerund, it treats the action as something belonging to the person. This structure is typically more formal and is preferred in written English. It emphasizes the action itself as being performed by the possessor.

- **My arriving late** caused confusion.
- **Her singing** impressed the judges.
- **Our leaving early** surprised everyone.

Object pronoun before a gerund

Using an object pronoun before a gerund is less formal and more common in spoken English. Here, the pronoun is less connected to "owning" the action and instead focuses on the person themselves as the subject of the verb. Some grammarians consider this less correct in formal writing, but it's widely accepted in conversation.

- **Me arriving late** caused confusion.
- **Her singing** impressed the judges. (This example works with both forms, but "her" here is ambiguous.)
- **Them leaving early** surprised everyone.

Comparing meaning and style

While both forms are often understood the same way in casual speech, the possessive form is clearer and more standard in writing, especially when the action needs to be highlighted as a noun phrase. In rare cases, the choice can subtly shift the focus from the action to the person.

Form	Example	Use/Implication
Possessive + gerund	My forgetting your birthday upset her.	Focuses on the act of forgetting as my action
Object pronoun + gerund	Me forgetting your birthday upset her.	Focuses more on me as the person who forgot

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Form	Example	Use/Implication
Possessive + gerund	His interrupting was annoying.	Emphasizes the behavior (interrupting) as his
Object pronoun + gerund	Him interrupting was annoying.	Emphasizes him (the person), less formal

Summary of when to use each form

- For formal writing, prefer possessive pronouns before gerunds.
- In conversation, object pronouns are widely accepted and natural.
- If clarity about who is acting is important, the possessive form is safest.
- Certain expressions only sound correct with the possessive (e.g. *your being here*).

The distinction is subtle, but mastering these forms helps you sound both natural and precise in English, whether you're writing or speaking.

Style preferences in modern English

Contemporary English usage shows a noticeable shift in how possessive pronouns are used before gerunds. While many traditional grammar guides insist on the possessive form (such as "my" in "my going"), actual patterns in published writing and everyday speech often diverge. This section explores current tendencies, practical considerations, and common exceptions.

Formal vs. Informal Contexts

Writers and speakers tend to follow stricter rules in formal contexts, using possessive forms before gerunds to clarify ownership or agency. In contrast, informal speech and casual writing often favor object pronouns or even omit the pronoun entirely. For example, "I appreciated his helping" is more formal, while "I appreciated him helping" is frequently heard informally.

- Formal: "We discussed **her joining** the team."
- Informal: "We discussed **her** joining the team." / "We discussed **her joining** the team."
- Conversational: "We talked about **her joining**."

Common Usage Preferences

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Native speakers often make choices based on flow and clarity, rather than strict adherence to rules. Some verbs tend to attract the possessive form, while others sound more natural with object pronouns.

Preferred in Modern Formal English	Often Used in Informal Speech
I object to **your leaving** early.	I object to **you leaving** early.
She appreciated **his helping** out.	She appreciated **him helping** out.
They insisted on **our arriving** on time.	They insisted on **us arriving** on time.
We were surprised by **their winning** the prize.	We were surprised by **them winning** the prize.

Factors Influencing Style Choice

- The level of formality required
- Whether the pronoun is singular or plural
- How natural or awkward the possessive sounds in context
- Regional and generational preferences
- Clarity—especially if confusion about the subject is possible
- Editorial guidelines (academic, journalistic, etc.)

Ultimately, both possessive and object pronoun forms are widely accepted in speech, and the choice often depends on audience, context, and clarity. For formal writing, the possessive is generally safer, but in conversation or informal prose, the object form is common and rarely misunderstood.

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Common learner mistakes

Many English learners struggle with using possessive pronouns before gerunds. This often leads to sentences that sound unnatural or are grammatically incorrect. The confusion usually comes from not recognizing when a gerund (the -ing form of a verb used as a noun) should be preceded by a possessive rather than a personal pronoun or noun.

Mixing up possessive and object pronouns

A frequent error is placing an object pronoun (like "me," "him," "her") in front of a gerund, when the possessive form is needed. For example, saying "I appreciate you helping me" instead of the more formal "I appreciate your helping me." While the object pronoun is sometimes accepted in informal speech, it is not standard in formal writing.

- Incorrect: *She didn't like him coming late.*
- Correct: *She didn't like his coming late.*
- Incorrect: *They were surprised by us leaving early.*
- Correct: *They were surprised by our leaving early.*

Forgetting the possessive with nouns

Learners sometimes omit the possessive form when the noun before the gerund is not a pronoun. For instance, "I object to John smoking here" is common, but "I object to John's smoking here" is more precise, especially in formal contexts. The possessive clarifies that it is John's action being discussed.

- Incorrect: *I didn't like Mary interrupting.*
- Correct: *I didn't like Mary's interrupting.*
- Incorrect: *The teacher noticed the student talking.*
- Correct: *The teacher noticed the student's talking.*

Confusing gerunds with participles

Another pitfall is misunderstanding when the -ing form is acting as a gerund (noun) versus a participle (adjective). Only gerunds require a possessive. For example:

- *I appreciated her singing.* (gerund; "her" should be possessive: "her singing")
- *I saw her singing.* (participle; "her" is the object of "saw")

This distinction can be tricky, but it's important for clear communication.

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Summary of correct forms

To help clarify, here is a comparison of common mistakes and their correct forms:

Incorrect Form	Correct Form
me forgetting	my forgetting
them arriving	their arriving
us missing the bus	our missing the bus
John missing class	John's missing class
her complaining	her complaining
you being late	your being late

Paying attention to these patterns will help avoid typical errors and make sentences clearer and more accurate. Remember, while informal English sometimes allows the object pronoun, using the possessive is generally preferred, especially in writing and formal situations.

Academic vs conversational contexts

How possessive pronouns are used before gerunds often depends on the setting—whether it's a formal academic paper or everyday speech. In more scholarly writing and professional communication, you're likely to see possessive forms like "my," "your," or "their" preceding gerunds for clarity and correctness. For instance, "We appreciate your coming to the meeting" is preferred in essays or reports. In contrast, informal conversations often drop the possessive, leading to sentences like "We appreciate you coming to the meeting." Both forms are common, but expectations shift with context.

Common Patterns in Each Context

When deciding whether to use a possessive pronoun before a gerund, it helps to be aware of the expectations in different situations. Here's how the patterns typically break down:

- **Formal/Academic:** "I object to *his* leaving early."
- **Informal/Conversational:** "I object to *him* leaving early."
- "We appreciate *your* helping us." (preferred in writing)
- "We appreciate *you* helping us." (common in speech)
- "There's no point in *their* arguing." (formal)

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- "There's no point in *them* arguing." (casual)
- "She was annoyed by *my* interrupting." (academic)
- "She was annoyed by *me* interrupting." (spoken)
- "Do you mind *my* asking a question?" (formal)
- "Do you mind *me* asking a question?" (informal)

Guidelines for Choosing the Form

Here are some practical tips to help you decide which form to use:

- Use the possessive + gerund in formal writing, academic assignments, and professional emails.
- Expect the object pronoun + gerund in friendly conversation, text messages, or informal online posts.
- Listen to your audience: teachers and editors may expect the more traditional structure, while friends won't mind the casual alternative.
- Some verbs and phrases almost always take the possessive in writing (e.g., "the likelihood of *his* succeeding").
- Regional differences exist, but the distinction is recognized in both American and British English.

Side-by-Side Comparison

Formal/Academic Example	Informal/Conversational Example
I appreciate **your** helping me.	I appreciate **you** helping me.
He didn't like **their** arriving late.	He didn't like **them** arriving late.
We were surprised by **her** winning the prize.	We were surprised by **her** winning the prize. (both forms sometimes used)
There's no chance of **my** finishing on time.	There's no chance of **me** finishing on time.

Ultimately, adjusting your use of possessive pronouns before gerunds helps your language sound natural and appropriate for the situation. Recognizing the difference can boost your confidence in both academic and everyday communication.

Practice: choose possessive or object forms

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It's common to feel uncertain about whether to use a possessive pronoun or object pronoun before a gerund in English. This section provides a range of exercises to help you distinguish between these two forms and use them accurately. Read the sentences carefully and decide which form best completes each one.

Exercise 1: Fill in the blanks

Choose the correct form (possessive or object) to complete each sentence. Write your answer in the space provided.

1. I appreciate _____ helping me with the project. (he/his)
2. They didn't like _____ arriving late. (us/our)
3. We were surprised by _____ winning the award. (she/her)
4. Would you mind _____ calling back later? (me/my)
5. He was annoyed at _____ interrupting him. (them/their)
6. She insisted on _____ taking notes during the meeting. (him/his)
7. Do you remember _____ leaving the keys here? (you/your)
8. The teacher noticed _____ talking during the lesson. (we/our)
9. I don't recall _____ saying that. (her/she)
10. We appreciate _____ supporting our decision. (you/your)

Answers:

- his
- our
- her
- my
- their
- his
- your
- our
- her
- your

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Comparison Table: Possessive vs Object Pronouns Before Gerunds

The table below summarizes the most common forms. Use this as a quick guide when deciding which pronoun to use with gerunds.

Subject	Possessive Pronoun + Gerund	Object Pronoun + Gerund	Example with Gerund
I	my	me	my/ me leaving
you	your	you	your/ you arriving
he	his	him	his/ him helping
she	her	her	her helping
we	our	us	our/ us participating
they	their	them	their/ them joining

Quick Practice: Identify the Correct Usage

For each sentence, select whether the underlined pronoun is correct or should be replaced with the other form.

1. I appreciate him helping me.
2. We were surprised by her winning.
3. They didn't enjoy us singing.
4. Would you mind my calling later?
5. She objected to them arriving so late.
6. The manager disliked him questioning the decision.
7. Do you remember me telling you about this?
8. Everyone praised her speaking so confidently.
9. We discussed him taking over the project.
10. They were annoyed by us interrupting the meeting.

Answers

1. Incorrect; should be **his**
2. Correct

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3. Incorrect; should be **our**
4. Correct
5. Incorrect; should be **their**
6. Incorrect; should be **his**
7. Incorrect; should be **my**
8. Correct
9. Incorrect; should be **his**
10. Incorrect; should be **our**